The East Trail Is Hers

Yara leads, and the village watches

Yara is seventeen, half human and half Vey'kar, and last night she brought the word home instead of chasing the man who set the snares. Tonight she leads the east trail herself, with Zola as her tracker — and the question of what her mother keeps of her father presses closer than ever.

Daughter of Two Worlds was written by BiomassFlood, with AI assistance from Luna for drafting and editing. All characters, worldbuilding, and story decisions are the author's own original work.

CHAPTER 5

DUSK, AND A PROMISE

The second night began the way the first one had ended: with Yara standing in the doorway of Oya's hut, her cloak folded over one arm, waiting to be told she was ready, and knowing she would not be told any such thing. Oya was sitting on the floor with her back to the wall, mending a spear shaft, and she did not look up when Yara came in. Her hands moved steadily, wrapping sinew in tight, even turns, and Yara understood, without being told, that her mother was doing the same thing she had done at the fire the night before: keeping her hands busy so that her fear would have somewhere to sit that was not her face.

"You are early," Oya said, and her voice was level, the way it was when she was giving orders, though there was a softness under it that Yara had learned to listen for.

"I wanted to be early," Yara said, and she kept her own voice level too, though her heart was beating hard enough that she could feel it in her throat. "So that if I am afraid, I can be afraid early, and be done with it before the trail."

That made Oya look up at last, and the corner of her mouth moved, not quite a smile, more like a door opening a crack. "Fear is not a thing you finish," she said, setting the spear shaft down across her knees, "like a bowl of roots. It walks with you. You only decide whether it walks in front of you, where you can see it, or behind you, where it can push."

Yara nodded, and then, because the hut was quiet and no one else was listening, and because the question had been pressing at her since the night before, she asked it.

"The charm," she said, and her hand went to her own belt, where the carved bone hunter's charm was tucked safe against her hip, warm from her skin. "The one you kept. His."

Oya went very still. Her fingers stopped on the sinew, and her markings, which had been low and even all evening, brightened for a moment along her arms, the way they did when a feeling got too big to hold quietly. Then she breathed out, slow, and the light dimmed again, and she looked at Yara the way she had looked at her on the temple steps: as a queen looking at her heir, and as a mother looking at her daughter, both at once.

"I kept it," Oya said, carefully, choosing each word the way she chose footing on a wet trail, "because it was his, and because throwing it away would have been pretending he had never been here. I do not pretend. Not about him. Not about anything."

"Then why will you not talk about him?" Yara asked, and her voice came out smaller than she meant it to, and she hated that, and went on anyway. "I am seventeen. I am old enough to be sent out on the east trail with a man setting snares in our jungle, and I am not old enough to be told what my own father kept in his pockets?"

Oya was quiet for a long moment, and Yara watched her mother's face do something it almost never did in front of anyone: it softened, and then it hurt, and then it steadied itself again, like a hand closing around a wound.

"Ask me again," Oya said, at last, "when the east trail is yours by daylight too, and not only by dark. That is not a refusal, Yara. It is a promise with a time on it. Lead the trail tonight, come home with the word, and I will tell you one true thing about him that I have never told you before. One. And then we will see."

Yara felt her breath catch, and then settle, and something in her chest stood up straighter. One true thing. It was not everything, but it was a door, and it was open a crack, and it was hers to walk through if she came home.

"One true thing," she said, and her markings flared once, bright and gold, before she breathed them down again. "I will hold you to that."

“I would expect nothing less,” Oya said, and she picked up the spear shaft again, and her voice, when she spoke next, was the queen’s voice again, level and carrying. “Now go. Zola is waiting, and she is only patient for so long, and I think that long has already passed.”

THE WATCH IS GIVEN OUT

Zola was waiting at the edge of the clearing, as Oya had said, and she was not waiting patiently at all. She was pacing a short, worn track in the dust, three steps one way and three steps back, her spear tapping against her shoulder with every turn, and when she saw Yara she stopped dead and threw both hands in the air.

“There she is,” Zola said, loud enough for the whole clearing to hear, and her grin was wide and bright, though Yara could see the worry underneath it, the way she always could with Zola. “Our leader. Our princess of the east trail. I was beginning to think you had decided to lead it from inside your mother’s hut, by thinking very hard at it.”

“I was talking to my mother,” Yara said, and she tried to sound dignified, and failed, because Zola’s grin was catching, and because the fear in her own chest was loosening a little, the way it always did when Zola was near.

“Talking,” Zola said, and she fell into step beside Yara as they crossed the clearing towards the fire, her shoulder bumping Yara’s, companionable and warm. “While I have been out here, alone, being brave for two people. Do you know how heavy that is? I had to be brave, and also be the tracker, and also be the one who remembers the orders, because you were not here to remember them with me.”

“I remember the orders,” Yara said, and she felt the words settle her, the way a spear settles in the hand when the grip is right. “Walk it. Close it behind us. Count what has changed. Touch nothing we do not have to. Word before meat. Word before pride. Word before everything.”

Zola nodded, and her teasing fell away for a moment, and she looked at Yara the way she had looked at her on the night trail, when the work had been real and the dark had been real with it. “And if he is out there?” she asked, quietly, so that only Yara could hear. “The man who laid the line. If he is out there tonight, reading it?”

“Then we do not follow where it leads,” Yara said, and she said it slowly, because she wanted to hear herself say it, and believe it. “We come home and say it first. That is the order. That is what leading means, I think. Not being the bravest. Being the one who brings the word home.”

At the fire, Oya was already standing, and the village was already gathering, and Yara saw, with a small shock of understanding, that the evening was different from the night before. Last night the fire had been kept calm on purpose, and nobody had talked about the wire. Tonight the village knew. The hunters stood in pairs, the way they had been told to, and the builders had their spears, and the night watch was already armed, and there was a new sound in the clearing: a low, steady readiness, like a river finding its course.

Oya gave the night out in pieces, the way she always did, and Yara listened with her whole body, the way she had learned to. The river trail to the same two older hunters. The north slope to the same two builders. The west trail, the old one towards the human paths, to Jabari, alone, as before, and Jabari received it the way he received weather, his face giving nothing away.

“And the east trail,” Oya said, and her gaze travelled once round the steps before it settled, and the coals ticked in the pause, “to Yara. To lead. And to Zola, to walk as her tracker.”

There was a small silence, and Yara felt it in her teeth, the way she had felt it the night before, but this time the fear that dropped through her stomach was smaller, and under it, slower and steadier, came something she recognised now: pride, and the weight of it, both at once.

“Yara leads,” Jabari said, from where he stood at the edge of the steps, and his voice was flat, and cold, and it carried across the whole clearing. “A girl of seventeen, half human, leads the trail where a man sets snares. Tell me, Oya. Is that leading, or is that hoping?”

The clearing went very slightly quiet, the way a pond goes quiet under one finger, and Yara felt every eye turn towards her, and her markings flared, bright and blue, before she could stop them.

Oya did not raise her voice. Her hand stayed flat and steady at her side, her markings low and even. “It is leading,” she said, calmly, from where she stood. “She brought the word home last night, when following would have been easier. That is what a leader does. If you doubt it, Jabari, walk your own trail, and let her walk hers.”

Jabari looked at Yara for a long moment, his old eyes level and wintry, and Yara made herself meet them, and not look away, and not dim her markings, and not shrink.

“Walk it, then,” he said, at last, and he turned away, already walking towards the west trail, not looking back. “And bring the word home. If there is a word to bring.”

FIRST ON THE TRAIL

The east trail began the way it always began: with the light going first, and then the sound, and then the smell, until there was only the dark and the jungle and the two girls moving through it.

Yara went first this time, and that was the whole difference, and it was everything. Last night she had walked behind Zola, watching her friend read the ground, and it had been Zola’s trail to lead and Yara’s to learn. Tonight the trail was hers to read, and Zola walked half a pace behind her, close enough to catch her if she fell, far enough back that the leading was real.

“It feels different,” Yara whispered, after a while, and her voice sounded too loud in the dark, even whispered, and she winced at it. “Being first. I can feel the trail watching me back.”

“It is not watching you,” Zola whispered back, and her whisper came with a grin in it, though Yara could not see it, only hear it. “It is waiting to see if you are worth watching. There is a difference. My grandmother used to say the trail tests everyone the first time they lead it, and it does not grade on a curve.”

Yara breathed out, slow, the way Amara had taught her, and felt her markings dim, and her senses settle, and the jungle come back into focus around her. The river first, always, the great low note under everything. Insects in layers, near and far, stitching the dark together. A night bird, offended about something, far to the left. Water over stone. The breathing of the girl behind her, who moved in a quiet so complete it had texture, like cloth.

She was doing the healer’s breathing, she thought, and the thought made her smile a little, in the dark, where no one could see it. She was doing the healer’s breathing, and the healer’s face, and she was leading a trail, and her mother had promised her one true thing about her father, and for a moment, walking first in the dark, she felt like all of her at once: hunter and human, daughter and leader, afraid and steady, and it did not tear her in two the way she had always feared it would.

The trail bent down towards the gully, and Yara slowed, and put her hand up, fingers spread, the way Zola had taught her, and Zola stopped behind her without a sound.

“Here,” Yara said, very quietly, and her voice was steady, and she was proud of that, and frightened by it, both at once. “This is where it was. The snare gully. Smell.”

Zola’s nose lifted, and her whole body went alert, the way it did when the ground had something to say. “Wire,” she breathed. “And something else. Something new.”

Yara crouched, and let her fingers hover over the ground without touching it, and let her senses do the work they had been taught to do. The smell of wire, yes, faint and cold, and under it, something she had not smelled before: a sharp, sweet smell, like dried meat left too long in the sun, and the smell of oil, cleaned metal, the smell from the prologue of her own fear, though she did not know that yet, and would not know it until later.

“He has been back,” she said, and her throat closed round the words, and she made herself say them anyway, clearly, so that Zola would hear them true. “Since last night. The line has been read.”

THE RESET SNARE

The snare was new. That was the first thing Yara understood, and the second thing she understood was that it had been set by a hand that was not in a hurry.

It hung in the same place the third snare had hung, in the narrow part of the gully where an animal had to step, and it was wire, bright and clean, and it was baited: a small piece of dried meat, tied with a short length of vine, hanging just above the loop, so that whatever came for the meat would put its foot in the wire first.

“He reset it,” Zola said, and her voice was low and flat, the way it went when she was frightened and did not want to show it. “He came back, he saw his snares were gone, and he set a new one. In the same place. He is not afraid of us. He does not know we are here, or he does not care.”

“He knows something is here,” Yara said, slowly, her breath evening out as the shape of him came clear in her mind, the way it had come clear the night before. “Think like the one who laid it. That is what Jabari said. He lost two snares, and he did not leave. He came back, and he set a better one, with bait, because he wants to know what took them. He is patient. He is tidy. He is certain, and he is not afraid to be certain in the dark.”

She looked at the ground around the snare, and read it the way she had been taught to read it, slowly, and out loud, so that Zola could hear her thinking, and so that she could hear herself think.

“One boot,” she said, pointing without touching, her finger hovering over the print pressed into the soft earth at the edge of the gully. “Here, and here. The same boot as last night, I think, the same size, the same tread, but deeper this time. He was carrying something heavy when he came back. A bag, maybe. Or a trap, bigger than the snare. And here —” she moved her hand, and Zola leaned in close beside her, their shoulders touching in the dark, “— here he knelt. The ground is pressed flat, in the shape of a knee. He knelt to set the wire, and he stayed kneeling a while, because he was listening. He was listening for us.”

Zola was quiet a moment, studying her in the dark, the teasing gone out of her face. “That is a frightening amount to get from one boot and a piece of meat,” she said, and her voice was soft, and admiring, and a little bit afraid, all at once.

“It is what Jabari said,” Yara said, and she lifted one shoulder, a tight little shrug, and let out a breath she had been holding. “Think like the one who laid it. And I am thinking like him, and what I am thinking is that he will come back again, and soon, and next time he will not only read his line. Next time he will wait beside it.”

She stood up, slowly, and her knees ached from crouching, and her markings were bright along her arms, and she breathed them down, deliberately, the way Amara had taught her, because a leader could not be a lantern on a trail where a man was watching.

“Close it,” she said, and her voice was steady, and it was her voice, and it was also, she realised, her mother’s voice, the way Oya’s voice sounded when she gave an order she wished she did not have to give. “We close it, the way we were told to. We take the wire, we take the bait, and we leave nothing for him to read but an empty gully. And we leave him a mark.”

“A mark?” Zola asked, and her eyebrows went up in the dark.

“A Vey’kar mark,” Yara said, and she bent, and with the tip of her knife she cut a small, clean sign into the bark of the tree above the gully: three short lines, and a circle, the sign for watched, and for warned, and for we see you. “Only Kijani can read it. But he will see that something was here, and that it took his snare, and that it left him nothing. Let him wonder what it was. Wondering is better than knowing. Knowing is what he wants.”

Zola looked at the mark, and then at Yara, and her grin came back, slow and bright. “You are starting to sound like a queen,” she said, and she said it fondly, and Yara felt her face go warm in the dark.

“I am starting to sound like my mother,” Yara said, and she laughed, quietly, because it was true, and because it frightened her a little, and because it steadied her too. “Do not tell her. She will only say she told me so.”

A COUGH IN THE DARK

They had closed the snare, and taken the wire, and left the mark, and they were on their way home, walking the trail back towards the village in the dark, when Yara heard it.

It was not a loud sound. It was the kind of sound that would have meant nothing to anyone who was not listening for it, and everything to someone who was: a twig, snapping, somewhere off the trail to their left, and then, a moment later, a cough.

A human cough. Short, and smothered, and swallowed almost as soon as it had escaped, as if the man who had made it had clapped a hand over his own mouth the instant he heard himself.

Yara froze. Her whole body went still, the way a hunted animal goes still, and then, a heartbeat later, the way a hunter goes still, and she put her hand up, fingers spread, stop, and Zola stopped behind her without a sound, and without a question, because Zola knew that hand, and what it meant.

“He is here,” Yara breathed, and her voice was barely a sound at all, and her markings were bright, so bright that she could see their blue light on the leaves in front of her, and she breathed, slow, and breathed them down again, until the dark closed back over them. “He is out there. To the left. Not on the trail. Off it, in the trees, watching the gully.”

Zola’s hand found Yara’s arm in the dark, and gripped it, hard, and Yara could feel her friend’s fingers trembling, just a little, and her own fingers trembling too, and she understood, with a clarity that frightened her, that this was the moment the orders were for. This was the moment when following would have been easier, and when following would have been wrong.

“We could follow him,” Zola whispered, and her voice was tight with the want of it, and with the fear of it, both at once. “We could follow him, and see where he goes, and see what he carries, and then we would know. Yara, we would know.”

“I know,” Yara said, and her throat was tight, and her heart was beating hard enough that she could feel it in her teeth, and she wanted to follow him too, so much that her feet were already leaning that way, towards the trees, towards the cough, towards the answer. “I want to know too. But the order is the order. Word before pride. Word before everything. If we follow him, and he sees us, then he knows, and then Kijani is not hidden any more. And if we follow him, and he does not see us, we still come home late, and my mother sends the watch out after us, and then there are more of us in the dark, and more of us to be seen.”

She was quiet for a moment, listening, and the jungle was quiet with her, holding its breath, and then she heard it again: a soft sound, further away this time, a footstep, careful and slow, moving away from the gully, back towards the human paths, and she understood that he was leaving, and that he had not seen them, and that he had come, and read his emptied line, and found nothing, and gone.

“He is leaving,” she said, and her voice was steady now, and she was proud of that, and frightened by it, both at once. “Let him go. Let him go home with nothing but a missing snare and a mark he cannot read. That is the word. That is what we bring home.”

Zola was quiet for a long moment, and Yara could feel her friend’s grip loosening on her arm, slowly, reluctantly, and then Zola let out a breath, long and shaky, and laughed, very quietly, in the dark.

“You are a terrible tracker,” Zola whispered, and her voice was fond, and teasing, and relieved, all at once. “A terrible tracker, who will not follow a trail when it is right there in front of her. My grandmother

would be ashamed of you. I am going to tell her, when I see her, that you let a human walk away."

"Tell her," Yara said, and she started walking again, back towards the village, and her legs were shaking, and her hands were shaking, and she did not hide it from Zola, because Zola was her friend, and friends did not have to hide shaking hands. "Tell her I let him walk away, and that I brought the word home instead. Tell her that is what leading is."

THE REPORT

The fire had burned low by the time they came home, and the village was waiting, and Yara felt the weight of every eye on her as she crossed the clearing, and her markings were bright, and she did not try to dim them, because she was too tired to hide, and because, she realised, she did not want to hide.

Oya was standing on the temple steps, and Jabari was standing at the edge of the steps, and Amara was sitting by the fire, and the whole village was gathered in the clearing, quiet, waiting for the word.

Yara stopped at the foot of the steps, and Zola stopped beside her, half a pace behind her, the way a tracker stands behind a leader, and Yara took a breath, slow, and let it out, slow, and spoke.

"The east trail is closed," she said, and her voice was steady, and it carried across the clearing, and she was surprised by how steady it was, and how much it sounded like her mother's voice. "The snare is gone. He reset it, with bait, in the same place, and we took it, and we took the bait, and we left him nothing to read but an empty gully, and a mark only we can read."

She told them about the boot print, deeper this time, and the kneeling place, and the listening, and the patience, and the tidiness, and the certainty, and as she spoke she watched the village listen, and she watched Oya listen, and she watched Jabari listen, and she saw, in their faces, the thing she had been afraid she would not see: belief.

"And then," she said, and her voice went quieter, because this was the hardest part, and the part she was proudest of, "we heard him. Off the trail, in the trees. A cough. A footstep. He was watching the gully. He was waiting to see what took his line."

"And you followed him?" Jabari asked, and his voice was flat, and cold, and it cut across the clearing like a blade. "You heard the man who sets snares in our jungle, and you let him walk away? Tell me, girl. Is that leading, or is that fear?"

The clearing went very slightly quiet, and Yara felt her temper flare, hot and sudden, the way it always did when someone insulted her mother, or her people, or her, and her markings flared with it, bright and blue, and she breathed, slow, and let the feeling be there without feeding it, the way Amara had taught her, and the way Jabari himself had taught her, on the training ground, when he had said to think, and not to burn.

"It is leading," she said, and her voice was level, and her hands were still at her sides, and she looked at Jabari, and did not look away. "If I had followed him, he would have seen me, or he would not have seen me, and either way I would have come home late, and the watch would have gone out after me, and more of us would have been in the dark to be seen. I brought the word home. That is what my mother ordered. That is what I did. Word before pride. Word before everything."

Jabari looked at her for a long moment, his old eyes level and wintry, and Yara made herself meet them, and not look away, and not dim her markings, and not shrink, and then, slowly, the elder nodded, once, the way he had nodded on the training ground, when she had passed his test by letting a feeling be there without feeding it.

"She leads the east trail," Jabari said, and he said it to Oya, and to the village, and not to Yara, and that, Yara understood, was the point: he was not praising her to her face, he was telling the village, so that the village would hear it. "The girl reads the man who walks on it, and she brings the word home, and she does not chase what she cannot catch. Let her lead it. And let the watch be hers to order, in the east, until the trial."

Until the trial. The words hung in the clearing, and Yara felt them land in her chest, heavy and bright at once, and she looked at Oya, and Oya looked at her, and Oya's face did something it almost never did in front of the village: it softened, and it was proud, and it was afraid, both at once, and she nodded, once, slow and certain.

"She leads the east trail," Oya said, and her voice was level, and carrying, and it settled over the village like a hand settling over a fire. "And the watch in the east is hers. That is my word, and it is the village's word now."

ONE TRUE THING

After the fire, when the village had gone to its shelters and the coals had burned low, Yara found Amara sitting by the river, as she often did at night, with her satchel beside her and her hands in her lap, looking at the water the way other people looked at a fire: as if it were telling her something.

Yara sat down beside her, without being asked, and Amara did not look at her, and did not need to, and for a while they sat together in the quiet, listening to the river, and Yara felt the tiredness in her bones settle, and the shaking in her hands settle, and the pride in her chest settle, until all of it was still there, but quieter, and easier to carry.

"You did well," Amara said, at last, and her voice was calm, and patient, and wise, the way it always was, and Yara felt her throat go tight, because praise from Amara was rarer than praise from anyone, and it meant more, because Amara did not give it away lightly. "You did very well, Yara. Your mother is proud of you, even if she will not say it in so many words. She says it in orders, and in trust, and in the east trail being yours. That is how your mother says things."

"I know," Yara said, and she looked down at her own hands, and at the scar on Amara's left hand, pale in the dark, and she asked the question she had been carrying since the fire, and since the night before, and since she was seven years old, really, though she had only just found the words for it. "Amara. Did my father ever walk a trail like that? Did he ever follow a man, or let one walk away?"

Amara was quiet for a long moment, and Yara watched her face in the dark, and saw something move behind her calm, something tired, and guilty, and fond, all at once, and she understood, with a small shock, that Amara knew more than she was saying, and that she had always known more than she was saying, and that the knowing hurt her, the way it hurt Yara.

"Your father," Amara said, slowly, choosing each word the way she chose herbs, carefully, and with respect for what they could do, "walked a trail like that once. Not with a snare. With a question. He always came back to read it, too. He would sit, and wait, and listen, and he would not chase what he could not catch, because he knew that chasing would only frighten it away. He was patient, Yara. Patient, and tidy, and certain. Like the man on your trail. Like you."

Yara felt her breath catch, and then settle, and something in her chest stood up straighter, and then sat down again, because the words were a gift, and they were also a question, and she did not know which one they were yet.

"Is that all you will tell me?" she asked, and her voice came out smaller than she meant it to, and she hated that, and went on anyway. "One true thing, Amara. That is all I am asking for. One true thing about him."

Amara looked at her, and her eyes were kind, and sad, and steady, and she reached out, and laid her hand over Yara's hand, warm and scarred, and her fingers were shaking, just a little, the way old hands sometimes shake, and Yara held them still, gently, the way she would hold a bird.

"One true thing," Amara said, softly, so that it was for Yara and not for the river, and not for the night. "He loved your mother. And he loved you. And whatever took him from us, it was not because he stopped. Do you understand me, Yara? Whatever it was, it was not because he stopped loving you."

Yara nodded, and her throat was too tight to speak, and her markings were bright, and she did not try to dim them, because Amara was her mentor, and her second mother, and she did not have to hide from Amara, and for a moment, sitting by the river in the dark, she felt like she belonged, fully, in both of her worlds at once, and it did not tear her in two.

“Thank you,” she whispered, at last, and her voice was steady, and it was her voice, and it was also, she realised, her father’s voice, the way she remembered it from when she was seven: quiet, and curious, and brave in a quiet way. “Thank you, Amara.”

THE EAST TRAIL IS HERS

Yara walked back to her shelter alone, through the sleeping village, and the night was quiet around her, and the temple stood in the middle of Kijani, dark and gold and old, and the fire in the clearing had burned down to coals, and the watch was out on the trails, and the village was safe, for tonight, and she understood, slowly, that this was what leading felt like: not a crown, and not a spear, and not a test passed in front of everyone, but a quiet village, sleeping, because someone she loved had trusted her with the dark, and she had brought the word home.

In her shelter, she took the bone charm from her belt, and held it in her hand, and looked at it in the dark, and felt it hum, once, low and warm, the way it had hummed on the night of the second chapter, when Jabari had called her to the training ground at dawn, and she thought about what her mother had promised her: one true thing, when the east trail was hers by daylight too.

It was hers now, she thought, and her markings flared, bright and gold, and she breathed them down again, slow and steady. It was hers by dark, and it was hers by the village’s word, and it was hers by Jabari’s word, which was the hardest word of all to earn, and tomorrow, when the sun came up, she would go to her mother, and she would ask, and her mother would tell her one true thing about her father, and then she would know a little more, and the not-knowing would be a little smaller, and that, she thought, was how a mystery got solved: not all at once, but one true thing at a time.

And then, because she was seventeen, and because she was tired, and because she was proud, and because she was frightened, all at once, she laughed, quietly, in the dark, and put the charm back in its place, and lay down, and slept, and dreamed, not of snares, and not of the man in the trees, but of a river, and a man sitting beside it, patient and tidy and certain, waiting for a question to come back and be read.

He would come back. That was the truest thing she knew about him, truer than his patience, truer than his tidy line. A man does not abandon a question he has paid that much sitting-still for. He had lost three snares now, and found a mystery, and a mystery, to a man like that, was worth more than a deer.

He would come back to read his line again.

And next time, Yara thought, not with fear, exactly, and not without it either, next time the line would not be all he was reading for. Next time he would bring something bigger, and something heavier, and something that would not fit in a snare. And Kijani would have to be ready. And she would have to be ready. And the trial, whatever it was, would have to come soon, because the village could not wait for ever, and neither could she.

She slept, and the village slept, and the trails were watched, and the east trail was hers.

End of Chapter 5

Yara led the east trail for the first time, read the man who set the snares, and brought the word home instead of chasing him — and Jabari, in his own way, said she should lead it. But the man who set the line will come back, and Oya has promised Yara one true thing about her father.

Next: Chapter 6 — Act 2 begins. The village grows, and Yara meets a human by the river — one who hates the snares as much as she does — and Jabari calls for Yara's trial.

Book plan: 20 chapters, about 250 pages — Act 1 is Chapters 1–5, Act 2 is Chapters 6–14, Act 3 is Chapters 15–20. Chapters 1–5 are now written. Series: The Yara Chronicles. Book 1: Daughter of Two Worlds.

Daughter of Two Worlds was written by BiomassFlood, with AI assistance from Luna for drafting and editing. All characters, worldbuilding, and story decisions are the author's own original work.